

AIRBORNE: Female observers will fly in the Tu-142



Sureesh Mehta.

Women have been flying transport aircraft and helicopters in the IAF since the early 1990s but do not fly fighter aircraft. Naval observers operate onboard long range maritime patrol aircraft like the hulking Tu-142s and IL-38s which operate off-shore bases and hunt submarines and interdicting enemy surface vessels and anti-submarine warfare helicopters which fly off warships. They are the principal warfare officers in an aircraft and handle aircraft weapons like torpedoes, bombs and missiles, and deploy sonabuys to detect enemy submarines. As a senior naval official puts it, they are "in the thick of action". The training is the first stage of 'confidence building' before women can fly naval aircraft. **by Sandeep Unnithan**

Women Submarine Hunters

DELHI The Indian Navy has a versatile aviation arm, but unlike the air force, it does not have any women flying its array of helicopters and surveillance aircraft. But that is set to change very soon. The first of two women

observers are currently undergoing training at the naval academy INS Zamorin in Kerala and will join the navy next year. The navy plans to train them as observers to detect hostile submarines and launch attacks on

enemy surface and aerial targets. "Women will serve on our Tu-142 maritime patrol aircraft and could soon be flying our P-8Is (a long range maritime patrol aircraft to be acquired from the US)," says navy chief Admiral

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

After his expulsion from the CPI(M), Somnath Chatterjee may be persona non-grata for the party, but it was gratifying to see the wife of a prominent Politburo member call on the Lok Sabha Speaker last week on his 79th birthday.

VOICES

"If the UPA Government takes any sincere action to combat terrorism, it will get full support from our party."

Rajnath Singh, BJP president

"The biggest damage to the Left parties is Somnath Chatterjee's expulsion. It is more than the loss they have sustained in withdrawing support to the UPA Government."

P.A. Sangma, former Lok Sabha Speaker and NCP leader

"We have enough arsenal in our possession and a strong force to defend our country. We don't need to sign the nuclear deal for weapons. It has much larger implication."

Pranab Mukherjee, external affairs minister

"The prime minister's economic acumen failed when inflation rose. Post-trust vote, his shield of honesty was disarmed when wads of money were seen (in Parliament)."

Yashwant Sinha, BJP leader

"We will censor all films from now to check that only the name Mumbai is used in them. Those who come here must learn Marathi language and respect Maharashtrian culture."

Raj Thackeray, Maharashtra Navnirman Sena chief